

Volumetric Scenography for the Fashion Film Genre

444.2, a Posthumanist Journey in Virtual Reality

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ABSTRACT

444.2 is a volumetric 6-DoF VR fashion film presented for the category of XR theatre. It is the outcome of transdisciplinary practice-based research at the nexus of fashion, expanded imaging and digital media. The researcher's praxis emerges as rhizomatic, within a network of human and non-human agents. The project interrogates the notion of digital fashion bodies from a critical speculative and posthumanist [Braidotti, 2013] lens using Deleuzian concepts and diffractive methods. 444.2 stages fashion bodies as morphing figurations unfolding to a cinematic Afro-diasporic score. The volumetric scenography of black female bodies as celestial bodies in the virtual environment of the Southern African Large Telescope becomes an enactment of African cosmology. Posthumanistic performance emerges as an experience of pluriversal and decolonial [Escobar, 2018] performativity in VR.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Applied computing; • Arts and humanities; • Media arts;

KEYWORDS

Fashion Practice, Fashion Film, Virtual Reality, Posthumanism

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1 EXTENDED ABSTRACT

Fashion films normally consist of short video productions of fashion-centred stories and became a phenomenon in the early 2000s, with the advent of digital technology and the internet [Rees Roberts, 2018]. This shift democratized access to fashion films to a range of creators, enabling fashion image makers as well as designers to bypass the traditional fashion editorial gatekeepers towards broadcasting their work online. Ranging from commercial to conceptual, fashion films are most often found in 2D video format with few immersive explorations that include 360 films and XR technologies. As a fashion filmmaker, the author's practice-based research explores emerging technologies to expand on the storytelling and aesthetics of the fashion film genre for a transdisciplinary and critical artistic output. Her projects use fashion film techniques, the

visual language of science fiction film and the medium of XR to tell affective stories of technology.

Combining African cosmology and a marker of modern astrophysics through in-story configuration of the Southern African Large Telescope (SALT), 444.2 is a volumetric 6-DoF fashion film in the emerging style of XR theatre. The intention is for immersants to experience the film as an engaging and affective journey in VR. This project uses speculative methods to diffractively conceptualise a posthumanist storyline of African cultures as cultures of technology. Photogrammetry and LiDAR captures from the architectural and geographical space of SALT in Sutherland, South Africa, provide data to reconstruct a virtual twin from the existing environment. It is intended that the virtual reconstruction of the space re-mediate the geopolitics of the actual place as this terrain doubles up as the site of the original stargazers of Southern Africa. The site therefore forms the location to imagine a VR journey that performs a creative and ideological deterritorialization of (a) disparate areas of knowledge such as fashion and astronomy as purely Western episteme and (b) the technological sublime of digital fashion bodies and structures such as astronomical observatories as sole production of Western technological advancement.

As a Mauritius-born, South Africa-based BIPOC feminist artist, the author has produced 444.2 through her situated knowledge and by using fashion film as a lens to create a stereotype-defying story of African and diasporic African becomings: One that reminds that 'other' bodies, praxes and knowledge systems co-constitute modernity and the stories of fashion and technology, even if these have been systematically erased or occluded by the project of colonization [Jansen and Craik, 2016]. The posthumanist intent is two-fold. The film confronts power asymmetries within the performative [Butler, 1993] and representational through a transvaluation of myth. It is also concerned with questions of materiality [Barad, 2003], as it diffracts and configures fashion bodies as volumetric data in performance.

The project stages a female dancer of Afro-diasporic origins in choreographed performance, using an array of three Azure Kinect sensors synchronized for volumetric capture at RMIT Virtual Studio. The performance is cut to audio in a non-narrative fashion film style [Khan, 2012] by the author as fashion film director, and with the novel parameters of editing with video and depth data rendered as video segments through the Depthkit Studio workflow. These are reconstructed as volumetric 3D animated assets in Unity game engine in close collaboration with creative technologists based in South Africa. The volumetric scenography in the virtual environment of SALT unfolds to an original and cinematic Afro-diasporic score developed in collaboration across a network of artists in South Africa and Mauritius. The immersant is embodied in an affective, hybrid encounter; its hypnotic, audio-visual hapticity engulfs and transports through virtual dimensions.

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This process emerges as Deleuzian *agencement* [Deleuze and Guattari, 1987] in the way that coming together as actioned through practice and becoming are performative of empowerment and agency across a decentralized and distributed network of sociotechnical activity. *444.2* innovates in terms of the fashion film genre and can be put forward as the first volumetric fashion film to be presented in real-time VR. *444.2* as fashion film imagined through XR technology is potentially transformative, presenting a pluriverse and onto-epistemology as an alternative to a hegemonic view of the world that can only conceive of a singular narrative in one reality.

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